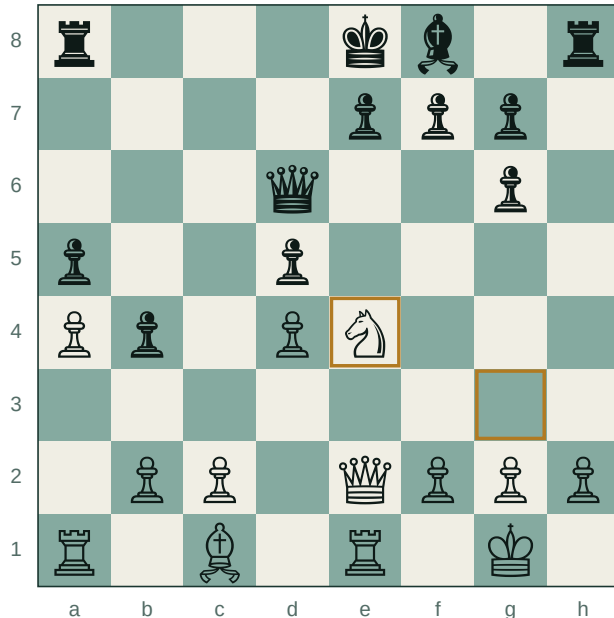


Mate in two: Black, move 17

Mate in two

Black to move



Previous move: 17.Nxe4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17...Qxh2+ 18. Kf1 Qh1#

17...Qxh2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on h2. Recorded reply: **18.Kf1**.

18...Qh1# Mate: queen on h1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on f1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on h1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The displayed line is one recorded defense. Test other legal replies instead of assuming the defender must copy it.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A mating combination must survive the defender's reply. The first move should force a position in which a second move ends the game against every defense.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the likely mating square and the defender that prevents it. Calculate the forcing move that removes that resource.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.